How to mix the colour and its shades

Brown is not one colour that you discover every time you fail to rinse your brush for long enough. It arises in several ways and each turns out a little differently. The more mixtures you try, the better you will see what you are looking for in it.

Ready-made brown tubes have their charm, but **mixing teaches you the most**. You will see how yellow, red and blue pull against each other, and when a warm earthy colour turns to mud. Start small, on paper, and write down what produced what.

What to prepare



Yellow
The base of warm brown and ochre shades.



Red
Gives a rusty or chestnut tinge.



Blue
In tiny doses it mutes and cools.



White
For beige, sandy and coffee shades.



Yellow ochre
A ready-made earth pigment that turns brown honey-like.



Sienna
Yellow-brown natural or red-brown burnt.



Umber
A muted brown, the burnt one is darker and warmer.

What sienna and umber mean

Raw sienna tends to be yellow-brown, burnt sienna a more distinct red-brown. Raw umber tends to be a muted brown, sometimes with a greenish tinge, burnt umber is darker and warmer. **The exact look differs between manufacturers.**

The names may sound like a guest list for a foreign tour, but on the palette they are very practical. You can also get brown by muting red with green or yellow with purple. The same shade will not always result.

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What the additions do



Yellow

Shifts toward warm, honey and golden. Add little by little.





Red

Shifts toward chestnut and rust. Watch for an over-brick look.





Blue

Cools and mutes. Add by the drop, it can take over the whole mixture.





White

Lightens to beige and sand. Too much white makes it a dull grey-brown.





Black

Shifts toward chocolate and almost black. Use only the tip.





Green

Mutes red undertones and adds a forest tinge.



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Ten browns to try

A part can be a drop or an equally large dab of paint. **Treat the proportions as a starting point** for experimenting, not as a guarantee of the same shade with every brand.

Basic warm brown



2 parts yellow and 1 part red, then gradually a small amount of blue. Warm and earthy.

Rust



An orange base and a little blue. Let the warm shade keep the upper hand.

Chestnut



Brown and a small amount of red. Glossy and deep.

Dark chocolate



Burnt umber and a trace of blue, adjust the red according to the result.

Honey brown



Yellow ochre and gradually added warm brown. Light and warming.

Sand



A lot of white, ochre and a trace of brown. Dry and calm.

Beige



White and a small amount of brown, for a warmer tone a trace of ochre. Soft and unobtrusive.

Coffee with milk



Gradually add brown into white. Friendly and homely.

Cool grey-brown



Brown and a tiny bit of blue, adjust the lightness with white. Quiet and urban.

Pink-brown



White, brown and a tiny addition of red or magenta. Soft and a little powdery.

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